

ONCE THERE WAS A ROAD Vehicles become part of the debris following flash floods in Kullu, Himachal Pradesh

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RAJINDER NEGI, AN APPLE GROWER IN KOTKHAI, HIMACHAL PRADESH, CAN ONLY SHAKE HIS HEAD IN DISBELIEF. His crop is rotting in warehouses or stranded on broken roads. Life itself seems broken in this Himalayan state: it has seen 45 cloudbursts, 91 flash floods and 105 major landslides so far this season, leaving over 660 road blockages in their wake. For Negi and countless orchard owners, the fallout is devastating, with up to 40 per cent of their apple harvest lost this year, a staggering blow to the Rs 5,500 crore industry. This, when they have only partially recovered from the 2023 floods. "We have rebuilt before," says Negi, "but this time the damage is too deep." His words capture the collective exhaustion of a community grappling with rapidly shifting climate patterns, which are upending their land and livelihoods.